

CM0081 Formal Languages and Automata

§ 3.1 Regular Expressions

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Preliminaries

Textbook

John E. Hopcroft, Rajeev Motwani and Jefferey D. Ullman (2007). Introduction to Automata Theory, Languages, and Computation.

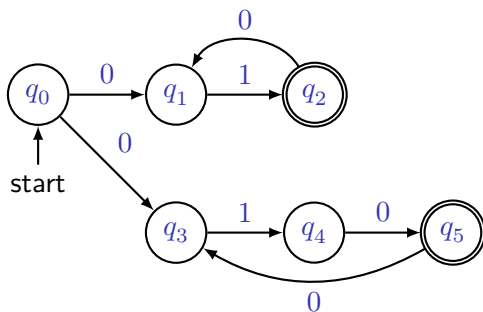
Conventions

- The number and page numbers assigned to chapters, examples, exercises, figures, quotes, sections and theorems on these slides correspond to the numbers assigned in the textbook.
- The natural numbers include the zero, that is, $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$.
- The power set of a set A , that is, the set of its subsets, is denoted by $\mathcal{P}A$.

Introduction: Description of regular languages

$(01)(01)^* + (010)(010)^*$

Algebraic description



Machine-like description

Introduction: Regular Expressions

Features

- Algebraic description of regular languages

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- Declarative (“user-friendly”) way to express the strings that belong to the language

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Introduction: Regular Expressions

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Uses

- Search commands (e.g. `GREP`)
- Lexical-analyzer generators (e.g. `LEX` and `ALEX`)
- Domain specific languages (DSLs)

Operations on Languages

Notation

The power set of a set A is denoted $\mathcal{P}A$.

Operations on Languages

Definition

Let L , L_1 and L_2 be languages on an alphabet Σ .

(i) **Union** of languages:

$$\begin{aligned} \cup : \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \times \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* &\rightarrow \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \\ L_1 \cup L_2 &:= \{x \mid x \in L_1 \text{ or } x \in L_2\}. \end{aligned}$$

(iii) **Powers** of a language:

$$\begin{aligned} (-)^{(-)} : \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \times \mathbb{N} &\rightarrow \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \\ L^0 &:= \{\varepsilon\}, \\ L^{n+1} &:= L \cdot L^n. \end{aligned}$$

(ii) **Concatenation** of languages:

$$\begin{aligned} \cdot : \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \times \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* &\rightarrow \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \\ L_1 \cdot L_2 &:= \{x \cdot y \mid x \in L_1 \text{ and } y \in L_2\}. \end{aligned}$$

(iv) **Kleene closure** of a language:

$$\begin{aligned} (-)^* : \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* &\rightarrow \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \\ L^* &:= \bigcup_{n \geq 0} L^n. \end{aligned}$$

Operations on Languages

Examples

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- If $L = \{0^n \mid n \geq 1\}$, then $L^* = L \cup \{\epsilon\}$.
- If $L = \{0, 11\}$, then L^* consists of the empty word and those strings of 0's and 1's such that the 1's come in pairs.

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- If $L = \{0, 11\}$, then L^* consists of the empty word and those strings of 0's and 1's such that the 1's come in pairs.
- Powers on $\emptyset$

$$\emptyset^0 = \{\varepsilon\},$$

$$\emptyset^i = \emptyset, \quad \text{for } i \geq 1,$$

$$\emptyset^* = \{\varepsilon\}.$$

What the Regular Expressions Are

Definition

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- Basis step
 - (i) ε is a regex,
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 - (iii) If $a \in \Sigma$ then a is a regex.
- Inductive step
 - If E and F are regex's then
 - (i) $E + F$ is a regex,
 - (ii) $E \cdot F$ is a regex,
 - (iii) E^* is a regex and
 - (iv) (E) is a regex.

Precedence of Operators

Order of precedence and associative

Precedence from highest to lowest: $()$, $*$, $\cdot$ and $+$.

Associative: The operators $\cdot$ and $+$ are left-associative.

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Example

$$\begin{aligned} 01^* + 1 &= (0(1^*)) + 1 \\ &\neq (01)^* + 1 \\ &\neq 0(1^* + 1) \end{aligned}$$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

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- Inductive step

Let $L(E)$ and $L(F)$ be the languages denoted by the regular expressions E and F , then

$$L(E + F) := L(E) \cup L(F),$$

$$L(E \cdot F) := L(E) \cdot L(F),$$

$$L(E^*) := (L(E))^*,$$

$$L((E)) := L(E).$$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

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$a + b$	$L(\mathbf{a}) \cup L(\mathbf{b}) = \{a\} \cup \{b\} = \{a, b\}$

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a^*	$\{\varepsilon, a, aa, aaa, \dots\}$

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$a + b$	$L(a) \cup L(b) = \{a\} \cup \{b\} = \{a, b\}$
a^*	$\{\varepsilon, a, aa, aaa, \dots\}$
$(a + b)(a + b)$	$L(a + b) \cdot L(a + b) = \{a, b\} \cdot \{a, b\} = \{aa, ab, ba, bb\}$

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$a + (ab)^*$	$\{a, \varepsilon, ab, abab, ababab, \dots\}$

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$a + (ab)^*$	$\{a, \varepsilon, ab, abab, ababab, \dots\}$
$(0 + 1)^*01(0 + 1)^*$	$\{x01y \mid x, y \in \{0, 1\}^*\}$

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$a + (ab)^*$	$\{a, \varepsilon, ab, abab, ababab, \dots\}$
$(0 + 1)^*01(0 + 1)^*$	$\{x01y \mid x, y \in \{0, 1\}^*\}$
$a_i(a_1 + a_2 + \dots + a_n)^*$	$\{w \in \Sigma^* \mid w \text{ starts by } a_i\}$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

Write a regular expression for the language L defined by

$$L = \{ w \in \{0, 1\}^* \mid 0 \text{ and } 1 \text{ alternate in } w \}.$$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

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Write a regular expression for the language L defined by

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Solution.

$$(01)^* + (10)^* + 0(10)^* + 1(01)^*$$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

Write a regular expression for the language L defined by

$$L = \{ w \in \{0, 1\}^* \mid 0 \text{ and } 1 \text{ alternate in } w \}.$$

Solution.

$$(01)^* + (10)^* + 0(10)^* + 1(01)^*$$

Other solution.

$$(\varepsilon + 1)(01)^*(\varepsilon + 0)$$

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

The regular expression

$$(10 + 0)^*(\varepsilon + 1)$$

denotes the set of strings of 0's and 1's that have no two adjacent 1's.

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

Write a regular expression for denoting the set of strings over $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$ not ending in 01 .

Languages Denoted by Regular Expressions

Example

Write a regular expression for denoting the set of strings over $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$ not ending in **01**.

Solution.

$$\varepsilon + \mathbf{0} + \mathbf{1} + (\mathbf{0} + \mathbf{1})^*(\mathbf{00} + \mathbf{10} + \mathbf{11})$$

Derivatives of Regular Expressions

Remark

The material on derivatives of regular expressions is from (Brzozowski 1964).

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Definition

Let $L \subseteq \Sigma^*$ be a language and $a \in \Sigma$ a symbol. We define the **derivative** of L by a , denoted by $\partial_a L$, by

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_a &: \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \rightarrow \mathcal{P}\Sigma^* \\ \partial_a L &= \{ x \in \Sigma^* \mid ax \in L \}.\end{aligned}$$

Derivatives of Regular Expressions

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The material on derivatives of regular expressions is from (Brzozowski 1964).

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Example

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_a \{abab, abba\} &= \{bab, bba\}, \\ \partial_a L(ab^*) &= L(b^*), \\ \partial_b L(ab^*) &= \emptyset.\end{aligned}$$

Derivatives of Regular Expressions

Definition

Let E be a regular expression on Σ and let $a \in \Sigma$ be a symbol. We define recursively the **derivative** of E by a , denoted $\partial_a E$, by

$$\partial_a : \text{RegEx} \rightarrow \text{RegEx}$$

$$\partial_a \emptyset = \emptyset,$$

$$\partial_a \varepsilon = \emptyset,$$

$$\partial_a a = \varepsilon,$$

$$\partial_a b = \emptyset, \quad \text{for } a \neq b,$$

$$\partial_a (E + F) = \partial_a E + \partial_a F,$$

$$\partial_a (EF) = \begin{cases} (\partial_a E)F + \partial_a F, & \text{if } \varepsilon \in L(E), \\ (\partial_a E)F, & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases}$$

$$\partial_a (E^*) = (\partial_a E)E^*.$$

Derivatives of Regular Expressions

Definition

Let E be a regular expression on Σ and let $w \in \Sigma^*$ be a string. We define recursively the **derivative** of E by w , denoted $\partial_w E$, by

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_w &: \text{RegEx} \rightarrow \text{RegEx} \\ \partial_\epsilon E &= E, \\ \partial_{ax} E &= \partial_a(\partial_x E).\end{aligned}$$

Derivatives of Regular Expressions

Theorem (Brzozowski (1964), Theorem 4.2)

Let E be a regular expression on Σ and let $w \in \Sigma^*$ be a string. Then

$$w \in L(E) \quad \Leftrightarrow \quad \varepsilon \in L(\partial_w E).$$

Libraries

Remark

Theoretical regular expressions $\neq$ practical regular expressions.

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Some programming languages with support to regular expressions

.NET, C, HASKELL, JAVA, MATHEMATICA, MATLAB and PERL.

Algorithms

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See the `HASKELL` implementation of some algorithms on regular expressions in the course homepage.

Applications

Some programs that use regular expressions

GREP: Print lines matching a pattern

AWK: Pattern scanning and processing language

SED: Stream editor for filtering and transforming text

ALEX, FLEX and LEX: Lexical-analyser generators

EMACS and VIM: Text editors

MYSQL and ORACLE: Databases

Applications

Reading

§ 3.3. Applications of Regular Expressions.

Applications

Reading

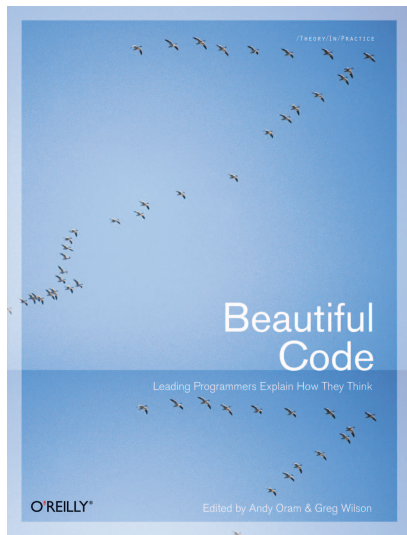
§ 3.3. Applications of Regular Expressions.

In the above section are defined:

$E^+ := EE^*$ (one or many times operator)

$E? := \varepsilon + E$ (zero or one time operator)

An Implementation: A Regular Expression Matcher



“Rob’s implementation itself is a superb example of beautiful code: compact, elegant, efficient, and useful. It’s one of the best examples of recursion that I have ever seen.”

Brian Kernighan, p. 3.

References

- Janusz A. Brzozowski (1964). Derivates of Regular Expressions. Journal of the ACM 11.4, pp. 481–494. DOI: [10.1145/321239.321249](https://doi.org/10.1145/321239.321249) (cit. on pp. [35–37](#), [40](#)).
- John E. Hopcroft, Rajeev Motwani and Jefferey D. Ullman [1979] (2007). Introduction to Automata Theory, Languages, and Computation. 3rd ed. Pearson Education (cit. on p. [2](#)).